



The Drakensberg

A gigantic, steplike, eroded landform that separates part of southern Africa's narrow coastal plain from its vast interior of savanna and desert



△ SAVAGE ARENA

In this part of the uKhahlamba-Drakensberg Park, the escarpment is shaped like an amphitheater. The pinnacles on the right are known as the Dragon's Teeth.

Meaning “Dragon’s Mountain” when translated from Afrikaans, the Drakensberg is the eastern part of a long, winding escarpment, the Great Escarpment, which forms the edge of a high plateau of central southern Africa. The Drakensberg is South Africa’s highest mountain range and runs for more than 620 miles (1,000 km) across eastern South Africa, with some peaks exceeding 10,000 ft (3,000 m) in height.

A giant, eroded step

From its base, the escarpment appears like a giant step. This is continuously worn down by gravity and the flow of water. The landscape is diverse, with steep cliffs, pinnacles, and caves. Rivers rising in the plateau behind the escarpment have carved some impressive gorges. The local fauna and flora includes vultures, rock hyrax, and 300 species of indigenous plants.

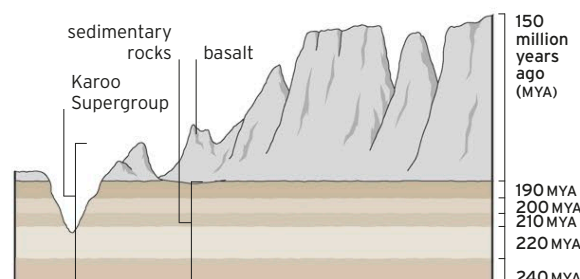


◁ GROUND-DWELLER

The indigenous Drakensberg rockjumper is a ground-nesting bird, which is often seen perching on rocks.

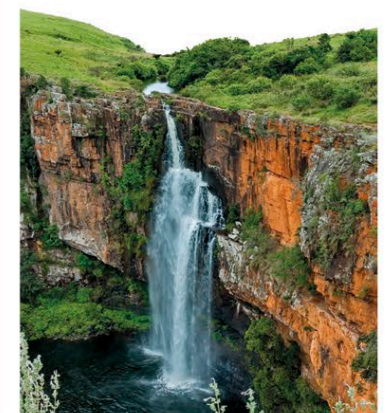
INSIDE THE DRAKENSBERG

The escarpment's steep sides consist of a thick layer of basalt (an igneous rock formed by cooling of lava), created as a result of ancient volcanic outpourings. Lower down are layers of older sedimentary rocks. Together, the basalt and sedimentary strata form part of a sequence of rocks found in a large part of Africa known as the Karoo Supergroup.



▽ FREE FALL

The Drakensberg boasts some of the world's tallest waterfalls, and other beautiful cascades, such as the Berlin Falls, shown here.



In places, the **escarpment is 4,900 ft (1,500 m) high** from base to top